of the people at Jantar Mantar were from there, as well as Chhattisgarh, Jharkhand and UP. The youth in these states are dependent on Public Services Commission (PSC) exams for social upliftment and are frustrated. They asked us why we were speaking only about NEET and not the PSC exams," he says. "This is a massive concern across India."

Another cause the CJP is keen to take up is that of gig workers of delivery apps. "The concept is fine for western countries as the society there is advanced. In India, gig working is nothing but exploitation of labour," says Dipke. "They need a safety net, and it'll require a major policy reform. They are putting their lives at risk for very little reward." The "long-term goal", of course, is an optimistic changing of the political discourse of the country. "Empathy and compassion are on the decline in society. As a society, we have started becoming sadists," Dipke notes.

The broader game plan has been evident over the past few days. The CJP has no intention, at least for now, of joining an existing political party or becoming one itself. Instead, it wants to remain nimble, describing itself variously as a "response group", a "pressure group" and a "people's movement" that hopes to expand organically across the country. If that doesn't sound like a traditional political agenda, it's because the CJP is not a conventional political organisation built around a single leader.

A CERTAIN RAWNESS

Two large paintings of B.R. Ambedkar fill the living room of Dipke's house where the strategy meetings are being held, proclaiming his politics with volume. In real life, however, the CJP leader comes across as a 'non-leader': soft-spoken, slight of build, dressed in a cotton tee. But anything he posts on Instagram—reel, live or story—is devoured by millions.

Political content creator Madri Kakoti, better known by her popular Insta handle Dr. Medussa, believes that's exactly what has worked.

"This generation craves a certain rawness in what they see on their phones," she says. "He's not the usual big influencer, always so prim and proper, so made up." For the Gen Z that experiences much of the world through phones, filters and memes, authenticity has become rare, she argues. "So anything that feels authentic, that feels raw, stands out."

Kakoti says she was involved in the CJP's backroom activities in its early days in May, and that this authenticity is no accident. "That's how we did it the first 14 days of the movement...we only put out uncurated, unedited videos." The advice clicked. Dipke's videos usually consist of little more than him picking up the phone and speaking into the camera. There is barely any editing. His colleagues, Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka, have much the same style.

THE CJP'S FUTURE SHAPE RESEMBLES THE SKELETON OF A PARTY. YOU DON'T HAVE ZONAL COMMANDS AND A CADRE IF PROTEST IS YOUR ONLY ENDGAME

If Kakoli deconstructs Dipke's appeal on social media, political scientist Yogendra Yadav believes in the right place, right time theory—the movement arrived at precisely the right political moment. "The fundamentals were already there, a deep unease among young people, both with education and jobs," he says. "The young in this country don't see a future for themselves in the way they could 20 years ago." The Supreme Court's "cockroach" remark, he argues, became the spark because it felt deeply personal to many unemployed young people. "So many young people told me, 'When I heard it, I thought he was speaking about me'," says Yadav.

Timing alone, however, does not explain why the protests snowballed. "The second was the use of memes," Yadav says, pointing to what Serbian activist Srdja Popovic describes as the 'dilemma action theory'—the idea that satire and pranks often put authoritarian governments in positions where every response only hurts them. The third ingredient, he says, was that the movement never visibly wore one political colour. "Those leading it did not carry any colour." Nor, he cautions, is it truly leaderless. "They have leaders. They have a decision-making structure. But they would like it to be less leader-centric, less hierarchical."



ABHIJEET DIPKE, 30

Founder & National Convenor

A political communications strategist, he founded Cockroach Janta Party on May 16 while in the US; returned to India, and launched protests in Delhi in June



SAURAV DAS, 27

Co-convenor

ASHUTOSH RANKA, 30

Co-convenor

CJP spokespersons, independent journalist Das and former McKinsey consultant Ranka, led the parlays with government ministers at the height of the Jantar Mantar protests